CHAPTER 24 Parliamentary Committees

MEANING

The Parliament is too unwieldy a body to deliberate effectively the issues that come up before it. The functions of the Parliament are varied, complex and voluminous. Moreover, it neither has adequate time nor necessary expertise to make a detailed scrutiny of all legislative measures and other matters. Therefore, it is assisted by a number of committees in the discharge of its duties.

The Constitution of India makes a mention of these committees at different places, but without making any specific provisions regarding their composition, tenure, functions, etc. All these matters are dealt by the rules of two Houses. Accordingly, a parliamentary committee means a committee that:

1. is appointed or elected by the House or nominated by the Speaker/Chairman
2. works under the direction of the Speaker/Chairman
3. presents its report to the House or to the Speaker/Chairman
4. has a secretariat provided by the Lok Sabha/Rajya Sabha

The consultative committees, which also consist of members of Parliament, are not parliamentary committees as they do not fulfil above four conditions.

CLASSIFICATION

Broadly, parliamentary committees are of two kinds—Standing Committees and *Ad Hoc* Committees. The former are permanent (constituted every year or periodically) and work on a continuous basis, while the latter are temporary and cease to exist on completion of the task assigned to them.

 **Standing Committees**

On the basis of the nature of functions performed by them, standing committees can be classified into the following six categories:

1. Financial Committees

(a) Public Accounts Committee

(b) Estimates Committee

(c) Committee on Public Undertakings

2. Department-Related Standing Committees (24)

3. Committees to Inquire

(a) Committee on Petitions

(b) Committee of Privileges